

Incremental summit wins will keep US-China relations stable

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【メール原文】

President Xi Jinping's visit to Washington 23–25 September will be a “success” because it extends the current period of US-China non-hostility. Senior

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Summit “success” through incremental deliverables that prevent deterioration of ties

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Senior Chinese officials indicated to Eurasia Group that their top goal is advancing the leaders' personal relationship, with progress on this front to come with an announcement of leader-level attendance at APEC in November and the G20 in December, establishing a historic rhythm of top-level engagement.

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Expect some tariff reductions under the new Board of Trade framework as well as movement towards extension of the Busan trade truce.

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The two sides will have challenging exchanges over global hotspots, including Taiwan and Iran, but they will keep those frictions out of view.

President Xi Jinping's visit to Washington 23–25 September will be a “success” because it extends the current period of US-China non-hostility. Senior officials in Beijing indicated to Eurasia Group that their top goal is advancing the leaders' personal relationship so that “constructive strategic stability” can remain in place through President Donald Trump's term, and possibly beyond (see: Managed decoupling will define US-China relations through 2031 , 27 August 2026). The two sides are thus set to agree on small wins that do little to address the substantive points of friction in the relationship, including continued issues surrounding export controls and critical mineral flows as well as growing tensions related to AI competition. Preparation has again been last minute, with the Chinese sharing considerable anxieties in the weeks leading up and subsequently downgrading their expectations for the summit.

Both sides see positive optics and pledges of future engagements as major summit outcomes. Xi's itinerary has been scripted to parallel that of the May summit except for one notable exception: Trump will be receiving Xi on the airport tarmac, a deviation from precedent that signals Trump's desire for a positive relationship with Xi. Both sides anticipate announcements of leader-level attendance at APEC in Shenzhen (November 18–19) and the G20 in Miami (December 14–15). If realized, Trump and Xi will have met four times in 2026 — twice in five months already, a frequency record — establishing a rhythm of personal engagement that is itself a form of bilateral stabilization.

A Chinese CEO delegation will add to the positive vibes but is unlikely to result in significant Chinese investment commitments. The delegation reportedly will include BYD, CATL, Xiaomi, Gotion, Bank of China, COFCO, and Innolight. Many of these companies are on US blacklists and face increasing

regulatory scrutiny. China, however, may clarify its purchase plans involving aviation and agriculture. While Trump is interested in Chinese investments, much of the rest of the US bureaucracy and Congress are not, especially Chinese electric vehicles. We do not expect Trump's expressed receptiveness to Chinese auto investment to bear fruit.

We expect tariff reductions on select goods and an extension of the export controls truce. A six-month extension of the export controls truce is likely, but it might occur closer to the 10 November expiration date due to frictions over rare earths. The Chinese would have preferred to extend the truce to the end of the Trump term, but the Trump administration believes that a shorter extension gives it more leverage. The He-Bessent preparatory meeting in New York on 20 September is likely to arrive at agreement on a specific list of goods to see tariff reductions under the new Board of Trade (see: Targeted bilateral tariff reductions likely centerpiece of September summit , 27 July 2026). We expect US agriculture and energy and Chinese manufacturing inputs. The two sides are set to focus on recent economic frictions, including continued concerns over Chinese rare earth flows and US FCC actions, perhaps defining additional economic actions that are prohibited under the truce.

Whether the two sides achieve incremental progress on AI discussions is a watchpoint. Breakthroughs are unlikely given mutual distrust and Trump's skepticism of AI safety concerns. Beijing sees calls from US companies to "pace the frontier" and calls on China to adopt stronger safety standards as efforts to suppress Chinese development. Chinese officials indicate recent negative comments from US AI firms alongside official US posturing about maintaining an AI lead has introduced uncertainty about when and how the two sides will productively engage. An agreement on safety standards and processes is unlikely, but both sides might establish a workplan for future AI discussions (see: Expectations falling for US-China AI dialogue , 3 September 2026).

Expect tart exchanges on Iran and Taiwan, but in private. Washington will raise concerns about Chinese oil purchases and the role of its banking sector in supporting Iran; Beijing will push back. The two sides are largely in agreement on keeping international waterways open and unimpeded but will not display this alignment publicly. Chinese officials continue to emphasize that Taiwan is the top issue for them in the bilateral relationship, but this will not be a major agenda item because they made significant progress in May (see: Beijing's growing confidence will heighten Taiwan risks after 2028 , 15 September 2026). Xi will reiterate the importance of delaying arms sales under "constructive strategic stability." Both sides have identified the need to expand military-to-military touchpoints and work toward crisis management arrangements. There may be a summit expression of intent on this front.

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